Armenia and is liberalizing internal trade and border controls between its members and harmonizing to World Trade Organization (WTO) commitments.[152] Russia accounts for 87 percent of the union's GDP and 83 percent of its population.[153]

Putin outlined his plans for a new type of Eurasian integration with Russia's ex-provinces in speeches and a 2011 newspaper article. The vision is grandiose but also infused with pragmatic elements, such as expanding markets and production chains. Unlike the past, twenty-first-century Russia is unwilling to pay the costs of empire, while its post-Soviet neighbors are wary of relinquishing their sovereignty to the regional hegemon.[154] Putin's original concept resembles Anatoly Chubais's 2003 idea of a "liberal empire" in the post-Soviet space, where Russia would be an economic magnet for the region.[155]

Over the long term, the goal extended beyond creating a single economic space to forming a currency union, and ultimately economic integration of states at the level of supranational institutions. Before the 2014 conflict with Ukraine, Putin envisioned a partnership with the European Union as part of a "greater Europe" from Lisbon to Vladivostok that would "change the geo-political and geo-economic configuration of the entire continent." Together with the BRICS, the Eurasian Union was expected to give Russia leverage in challenging Euro-Atlantic dominance and pave the way for genuine, equal partnership on more favorable terms. Thus, in better times, Putin had pictured Russia as leading the process of regional integration and the Eurasian Union as "one of the poles in the modern world," a "bridge between Europe and the dynamic Asia-Pacific region, . . ." "creating additional competitive advantages . . ." such as "setting the rules and shaping the future."[156]

To cement Russia's regional power, the Kremlin fully expected that Ukraine would become a key member of the EEU, insisting that it did not contradict potential members' "pro-European stance."[157] But by 2013, Kiev was on the verge of signing an Association Agreement, with provisions for a Deep and Comprehensive Free Trade Area with the EU, throwing a wrench into Putin's clearest geopolitical ambition. Russia offered a variety of subsidies to states to join the EEU, including cheaper gas loans and gas price subsidies for members of the customs union. Russia also agreed to bear the lion's share of the "accession costs" linked to Kyrgyzstan's and